A Moment Beside the River

Yellow highlighting marks added or revised wording.

Last year, my family and I went to Alaska on a cruise. During our visit to Skagway, we took a train through the woods along the edge of a mountain. As the train moved, cool air flowed around me, carrying the earthy smell of mud and wood. Below me, green trees spread across the slopes like a thick green blanket, stretching down farther than I could see. The sky was bright, and the air felt fresh. All of a sudden, a river appeared through the trees. Pale water rushed between large gray rocks, breaking into white swirls as it moved through the forest. Its roar reached me through the trees, like a voice rising from deep inside the woods. I was astonished by how fast and powerful the water looked. Yet right beside it, the trees stood straight and green, like guards who would not leave their posts. In such a cold place, I was surprised that I could not see any yellow leaves. The river seemed strong enough to sweep anything away, but the trees remained standing beside it. Watching the rushing water and the still trees together made me feel the majesty of nature. With the air moving around me and the woods stretching below, I felt like I was part of the landscape, even though I was riding on a train.

In that moment, a surge of courage rose in my heart. I saw myself in those trees, standing firm while the world rushed around them. The water seemed fierce, but the trees did not retreat. I wanted to carry that same strength inside me, to face whatever came without immediately backing down. Yet the longer I looked, the more I noticed that the trees belonged beside the river. They were rooted in the same landscape that made the water seem so powerful. I felt that way too: small beside the mountain, but still part of everything around me. The cool air brushed against me as if the woods were reaching out to include me. I could smell the earth and hear the river, and for a moment the distance between me and the forest seemed to disappear. That was what made the view astonishing. Nature could make me feel small and strong at the same time. Looking at the photograph now, I can almost hear the water again. I want to keep that feeling with me: the courage to stand tall and the comfort of knowing I belong.